Q.1The Primary Objectives of the Formation of BBIN

The **BBIN (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal) Initiative** is a sub-regional platform established in **2015 in Thimphu, Bhutan**, to enhance **connectivity, trade, and regional cooperation** among its member states. It emerged as a practical step toward regional integration in South Asia, especially in light of SAARC's limited progress.

Objectives of BBIN:

Enhancing Regional Connectivity:

One of the core objectives of BBIN is to establish efficient and seamless connectivity among the member countries through **road, rail, and inland waterways**. This aims to facilitate movement of goods and people, especially in remote and landlocked regions.

Improving Trade and Economic Cooperation:

BBIN seeks to promote **intra-regional trade** by simplifying **customs procedures**, facilitating **cross-border logistics**, and promoting **transport infrastructure**. The goal is to integrate regional markets and stimulate economic growth.

Promoting Tourism and People-to-People Contact:

The initiative emphasizes easing **visa and travel formalities** to promote tourism and increase **cultural exchange**. Greater people-to-people contact is expected to deepen mutual understanding and regional solidarity.

Establishing Transport and Transit Facilities:

A major milestone was the signing of the **BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement (MVA)** in 2015, which seeks to allow the **free movement of passenger and cargo vehicles** across borders without the need for transshipment. This would reduce transit times and costs, particularly benefiting landlocked Bhutan and Nepal.

Sustainable Development and Energy Cooperation:

BBIN also prioritizes **eco-friendly transport systems** and cooperation in the **generation and transmission of energy**, especially hydropower. This includes **cross-border electricity trade** and integration of national grids for energy security.

Strategic and Geopolitical Importance:

BBIN reflects a **functional, sub-regional approach** to cooperation in South Asia. It provides an alternative framework in the face of SAARC's inefficacy and helps **counterbalance China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)** by offering regional integration rooted in mutual benefit.

Bhutan's Position on MVA:

Although Bhutan signed the MVA in 2015, it has not ratified it due to **environmental and sovereignty concerns**, particularly related to the impact of increased vehicular traffic. However, **India, Bangladesh, and Nepal continue to operationalize the agreement** through bilateral and trilateral mechanisms.

Conclusion:

BBIN presents a **promising model of sub-regional cooperation** in South Asia. It addresses key challenges of **connectivity, trade, energy, and mobility** while fostering mutual trust among member states. However, its full potential can only be realized through **infrastructural investment, political consensus, and inclusivity**, especially in accommodating Bhutan's concerns. Despite being

limited to four countries, BBIN demonstrates the **pragmatic potential of regionalism** in the South Asian context.

Q2.Discuss the major problems of SAARC along with criticism. Highlight India's role in this context. (2021 H)

Introduction:

The **South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC)**, formed in **1985**, was envisioned as a platform for promoting peace, development, and regional cooperation among its eight member states: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka. **India**, being the largest and most influential country in the region, plays a pivotal role in SAARC. However, despite its potential, SAARC has failed to emerge as an effective regional bloc due to a multitude of political, economic, and structural issues.

Major Problems of SAARC:

Absence of Political Consensus and Mutual Trust:

SAARC suffers from a lack of political cohesion. **Historical animosity, particularly the India–Pakistan rivalry**, casts a long shadow on regional cooperation. Diplomatic tensions between these two nations have frequently led to **postponed or cancelled summits**, paralyzing SAARC's functioning.

Excessive Nationalism:

Member states often prioritize **domestic politics and nationalist agendas** over regional cooperation. The absence of a regional mindset hampers SAARC's objectives. **Rigid stances** on sovereignty and territorial disputes obstruct collective decision-making.

Economic and Resource Disparity:

There exists a **vast asymmetry in economic size, population, and resources**, with India significantly ahead. Smaller nations such as Bhutan and Maldives **fear economic dependence and political domination**, making them hesitant to commit fully to SAARC initiatives.

Uneven Developmental Levels:

SAARC includes countries at **varied stages of economic development**. While India, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka have relatively higher GDPs, nations like Nepal and Afghanistan lag far behind. This **disparity leads to unequal benefits** from joint projects and fosters resentment.

Weak Intra-Regional Trade and Economic Integration:

SAARC countries **trade more with countries outside the region than within it**. Intra-SAARC trade constitutes **less than 5%** of total trade, whereas in blocs like the EU, it exceeds 60%. Member countries **compete rather than complement** each other in global markets, especially in textiles, agriculture, and primary goods.

Fear of Indian Dominance:

Many smaller countries **perceive India as hegemonic**. India's size, economy, and strategic reach often lead to suspicions that it may use SAARC to expand influence. This has prompted **alliances with extra-regional powers** like China and the USA, complicating regional cooperation.

Lack of Tangible Achievements:

Despite grand declarations in summit meetings on

poverty alleviation, terrorism, and regional development, progress has been minimal. For instance, SAARC has been **ineffective in countering terrorism**, especially when some members themselves are accused of sponsoring or harboring terrorist groups.

Foreign Interference and Strategic Rivalries:

The region is influenced by **external powers**. The **United States** has used Pakistan as a strategic ally, and **China's growing presence in Nepal, Sri Lanka, and Bangladesh** threatens regional balance. Such interference **intensifies distrust** among members.

Failure in Poverty Alleviation:

Though **poverty eradication** is a declared SAARC goal, around **40% of the population** in the region still lives below the poverty line. Initiatives such as the **Independent South Asian Commission on Poverty Alleviation** (1991) and declarations in the **Delhi Summit (1995)** failed to achieve meaningful results.

Infrastructural Limitations and Poor Connectivity:

Poor **transport and communication infrastructure** hinders smooth interaction. As Prakash Chandra and Prem Arora rightly observe:

"The inadequacy of transport and communication facilities among the various members of SAARC constitutes an impediment in the way of smooth working of SAARC."

– International Relations

India's Role in the Context of SAARC:

India's **centrality and leadership** in SAARC is undeniable, given its **geographical location, economic size, and political influence**. However, this role is double-edged:

Positive Contributions:

=India has supported **trade liberalization**, **developmental assistance**, and **connectivity projects**.

=It initiated programs like the **SAARC Satellite**, **South Asia University**, and **SAARC Food Bank**.

Criticisms:

=India is often **accused of unilateralism** and ignoring SAARC mechanisms in favor of bilateral dealings.

=India's **refusal to attend the 19th SAARC Summit** (Islamabad, 2016) led to its indefinite postponement.

=India's shift toward **sub-regional groupings like BIMSTEC and BBIN** is viewed by some as **sidestepping SAARC** due to the Pakistan issue.

Conclusion:

SAARC remains a **dormant organization**, unable to rise above **geopolitical rivalries, especially between India and Pakistan**. For SAARC to revive and function effectively, there must be **political will, mutual trust, and an inclusive regional vision**. As the largest and most powerful member, **India must take a leading yet sensitive role** in fostering genuine cooperation without evoking fears of dominance. Only then can SAARC realize its founding dream of a **prosperous, peaceful, and integrated South Asia**.

What are the main principles or features of India's foreign policy? (2021 - H)

Introduction:

India's emergence in international politics is a relatively recent phenomenon. Since gaining

independence on August 15, 1947, India has managed to secure a significant position in global affairs. The country's foreign policy has been guided by a number of core principles that reflect both its historical experience and strategic vision.

Panchsheel:

One of the fundamental principles of India's foreign policy is adherence to Panchsheel. Inspired by Indonesia's *Panjat Shila*, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru proposed Panchsheel in 1954. These five principles include:

- Mutual respect for each other's territorial integrity and sovereignty
- Non-aggression
- Non-interference in each other's internal affairs
- Equality and mutual benefit
- Peaceful co-existence

Panchsheel served as the philosophical foundation of India's peaceful international conduct, especially with neighbouring Asian countries.

Non-Alignment:

India chose not to align with any power bloc during the Cold War, becoming one of the founding members of the **Non-Aligned Movement (NAM)**. Non-alignment did not mean neutrality or passivity — India took strong stands against colonialism, military aggression, imperialism, and the arms race, while maintaining independence in foreign affairs.

Anti-Imperialism:

India has consistently opposed imperialist domination. It extended support to liberation movements and condemned interventions in countries such as Vietnam, Korea, the Falklands, El Salvador, and Panama. India also provided diplomatic and moral support to countries fighting colonial rule.

Opposition to Neo-Colonialism:

India raised its voice against the modern tactics of imperial control such as military alliances, foreign aid with conditions, arms sales, and economic dependency. It advocated for the sovereignty and development rights of newly independent countries.

Support for National Liberation Movements:

Having experienced the pain of colonial rule, India actively supported decolonization movements in Asia, Africa, and Latin America. It supported the independence of Bangladesh, Ghana, Angola, Mozambique, Uganda, and Southern Rhodesia, among others.

Opposition to Racial Discrimination:

India was one of the earliest and strongest critics of apartheid in South Africa. It campaigned for the expulsion of racist regimes from international forums, and raised the issue of racial injustice in the United Nations and NAM summits.

Disarmament:

India has consistently advocated for universal and non-discriminatory disarmament. Although it conducted nuclear tests in 1974 and 1998, India maintains a **"No First Use"** policy and supports peaceful use of nuclear energy. It opposes the unequal nature of global treaties like the NPT and CTBT.

World Peace:

India's foreign policy slogan has always been **"Not war, but peace."** It played a role in the peaceful resolution of conflicts such as the Korean War,

Vietnam War, Arab-Israeli conflict, and the Iran-Iraq War. India contributed troops for UN peacekeeping missions and consistently promoted peaceful dialogue as a global norm.

Strategic Autonomy:

After the Cold War, India gradually moved from non-alignment to **strategic autonomy**, choosing its partners based on national interest. Whether cooperating with the USA, Russia, or France, or maintaining distance on issues like the Iraq War or Ukraine conflict, India has preserved decision-making independence in international matters.

Multilateralism and Regional Engagement:

India actively participates in platforms such as the **United Nations, G20, BRICS, SCO, BIMSTEC**, and the **Quad** to promote issues like counter-terrorism, climate justice, digital governance, and economic equity. It also promotes regional cooperation through policies like **"Neighborhood First"** and **"Act East."**

Evaluation:

Though based on noble ideals, India's foreign policy has sometimes displayed strategic flexibility and pragmatism, reflecting its national interests. While staying rooted in principles like non-alignment and peace, India has adapted to global shifts through **realism, balance, and strategic partnerships**. As a result, its foreign policy today is a combination of **idealism, sovereignty, and assertive diplomacy** in a multipolar world.

Q4, An Analytical Commentary on India's Security in South-East Asia in the Post-Cold War Era (2024-H)

Introduction:

For any nation, national security—especially concerning sovereignty and territorial integrity—is of paramount importance. Following the end of the Cold War and the dissolution of the Soviet Union, global geopolitics entered a multipolar phase. Southeast Asia emerged as a crucial strategic region due to its economic dynamism, maritime corridors, and geopolitical tensions. These transformations have compelled India to recalibrate its security and strategic postures in the region.

Geopolitical Context of Southeast Asia:

Southeast Asia serves as a vital maritime corridor linking the Indian and Pacific Oceans. Its growing economic influence and strategic location have attracted global powers. India views the region as central to its maritime security architecture, prompting it to significantly strengthen its naval capabilities, especially in the Indian Ocean and Andaman and Nicobar region.

India's Security Concerns in Southeast Asia:

India faces multiple security concerns in this region. China's ambitious **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)** and its **"String of Pearls"** strategy have increased Beijing's influence across South and Southeast Asia. China's assertiveness in the **South China Sea** raises concerns about India's trade and energy routes. Additionally, the presence of extremist and separatist groups in parts of Southeast Asia poses risks to India's northeast and eastern frontiers.

India's Strategic Measures:

India has transitioned from a **"Look East"** to an

"Act East" policy, actively deepening its economic, cultural, and defense engagement with Southeast Asian nations.

- India has forged robust defense cooperation with **ASEAN** members.
- As part of the **QUAD** (India, USA, Japan, Australia), it works to balance China's growing power in the Indo-Pacific.
- Infrastructure development in the **Andaman and Nicobar Islands** and strategic projects like **Chabahar Port** and **Sabang Port** reflect India's effort to secure maritime influence.
- Through **Maritime Domain Awareness (MDA)** and coastal surveillance initiatives, India supports regional partners like Vietnam and Indonesia.

Trade and Connectivity Diplomacy:

India is actively building infrastructure to improve regional connectivity and economic linkages.

- The **Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project** and the **India–Myanmar–Thailand Trilateral Highway** aim to strengthen India's physical and economic integration with Southeast Asia.
- **Free Trade Agreements (FTAs)** with ASEAN and participation in the **Indo-Pacific Economic Framework (IPEF)** broaden India's trade and strategic engagement.

Regional Rivalry and Strategic Balance:

India's core strategic objective is to maintain a balance of power in Southeast Asia and contain China's growing hegemony. To this end, India has:

- Initiated **naval exercises and defense agreements** with countries like **Vietnam, Philippines, Indonesia, and Malaysia**.
- Promoted multilateral platforms like the **East Asia Summit** and **ADMM+** for regional security dialogue.

Use of Soft Power:

India uses cultural diplomacy as a strategic tool to foster goodwill.

- Deep-rooted ties through **Buddhism**, **Sanskrit heritage**, and **education** are revitalized to connect with nations like **Thailand, Vietnam, Laos, and Myanmar**.
- India offers scholarships, technical training, and development aid to enhance people-to-people contact.

Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR):

India has positioned itself as a responsible regional power by engaging in disaster relief and humanitarian operations.

- The Indian Navy's role in post-cyclone and tsunami assistance has been praised, adding to its strategic credibility in the region.

Domestic Security and Northeast Development:

India recognizes that its engagement with Southeast Asia depends heavily on the **stability and development of its northeastern region**. Efforts are being made to counter internal threats such as terrorism, insurgency, and smuggling through infrastructure development and border management.

SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region):

Introduced in 2015, the **SAGAR doctrine**

encapsulates India's vision for regional security and economic growth in the Indo-Pacific. It emphasizes cooperation, collective security, and sustainable development in the maritime domain.

Evaluation:

In the post-Cold War era, Southeast Asia has transformed from a peripheral zone to a **strategic frontline** in India's foreign and security policy. In a region defined by **power rivalries**, **economic interdependence**, and **emerging security threats**, India's multi-pronged approach—leveraging diplomacy, defense, culture, and development—is crucial. To sustain and expand its strategic footprint, India must continue to pursue **strategic patience**, **multi-modal connectivity**, **internal cohesion**, and **regional partnerships** with consistency and foresight.

Conclusion:

India's evolving security strategy in Southeast Asia is a testament to its rising global stature and its resolve to shape a peaceful, stable, and multipolar Indo-Pacific. With calculated diplomacy, robust defense preparedness, and people-centric development, India aspires to secure its national interests while contributing to regional peace and prosperity.

Q5.Bangladesh's Strategic Importance in India's Foreign Policy – Explain (2024 H)

Introduction:

Bangladesh, which gained independence in 1971, shares deep historical, cultural, and geographical ties with India. Surrounded on three sides by India, it holds a **crucial place in India's foreign policy**, especially in the context of *Neighbourhood First*, *Act East*, and regional security. The strategic importance of Bangladesh to India is multifaceted, spanning economic, geopolitical, cultural, and security dimensions.

Geographical Location and Connectivity Advantage:

Bangladesh serves as a **land bridge** between mainland India and its northeastern states.

- India uses transit routes through Bangladesh for easier access to its northeastern region.
- **Ports like Chittagong and Mongla** are increasingly vital for Indian goods transport. This geographic advantage makes Bangladesh essential to India's **connectivity and logistics strategy**.

Economic and Trade Relations:

Bangladesh is one of **India's top trading partners** in South Asia.

- Major exports: agricultural goods, textiles, engineering products.
- Imports from Bangladesh: jute, garments, fish, and agro-products.
- Ongoing negotiations on a **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)** reflect deepening trade integration.

Regional Security and Counter-Terrorism Cooperation:

Bangladesh plays a key role in countering insurgency and cross-border terrorism.

- It has helped India curb activities of militant groups operating in the northeast.
- However, issues like **illegal immigration, smuggling, and human trafficking** continue to pose bilateral challenges.

Strategic Balance Amidst China's Presence:
India is wary of China's growing military and economic ties with Bangladesh:

- China is helping build Bangladesh's **deep-sea ports and military infrastructure**.
- To counterbalance this, India is investing in strategic infrastructure and strengthening diplomatic ties.
  Bangladesh thus becomes a **pivot state** in India's strategic rivalry with China.

Water Resources and Environmental Cooperation:
Over 50 rivers flow from India into Bangladesh, making **transboundary water-sharing** a sensitive issue.

- Disputes over rivers like **Teesta** and **Ganges** require sustained dialogue.
- The **Joint River Commission** coordinates efforts on equitable water distribution and climate adaptation.

Soft Power and Cultural Diplomacy:
India and Bangladesh share common **linguistic, cultural, and religious** bonds.

- India promotes cultural exchanges, education, and media cooperation.
- Shared heritage, especially **Bengali culture and the legacy of 1971**, strengthens India's soft power outreach.

Role in "Act East" and "Neighbourhood First" Policies:
Bangladesh is essential for India's connectivity with Southeast Asia.

- Through Bangladesh, India seeks to implement the **Act East Policy**, improving links to Myanmar, Thailand, and ASEAN nations.
- Bangladesh is thus a **strategic transit partner** for regional economic and political integration.

Transport and Connectivity Corridors:
India has initiated several multi-modal and transnational connectivity projects:

- **BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement** (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal)
- **BCIM Economic Corridor** (Bangladesh–China–India–Myanmar)
- Revival of **Stilwell Road** linking Arunachal to China via Myanmar
  These projects rely heavily on Bangladesh's active participation.

Energy Cooperation and Transit Hub Potential:

- Bangladesh imports electricity from India.
- India may access Bangladesh's **LNG facilities** in future.
- Electricity from **Nepal and Bhutan** can be transmitted via Bangladesh, enhancing regional **energy integration**.

Strategic Competition in the Bay of Bengal:
The **Bay of Bengal** is becoming a geopolitical hotspot.

- Bangladesh's newly acquired **exclusive economic zones (EEZs)** are attracting Chinese and Western interest.
- India seeks **maritime cooperation** with Bangladesh to limit China's influence and ensure regional maritime security.

Border Management and Internal Stability:

With **four Indian states** sharing borders with Bangladesh, cooperation is vital in:

- Curbing **illegal migration and smuggling**
- Addressing **insurgency in border regions**
  Recent **political unrest in Bangladesh** has added uncertainty to bilateral ties, making political stability in Dhaka critical for India.

Conclusion:

For India, Bangladesh is more than a neighbor — it is a **strategic gateway** to its northeast, to Southeast Asia, and to the Bay of Bengal. From trade and energy to security and soft power, Bangladesh plays a **central role in India's regional ambitions**. Thus, maintaining a stable, cooperative, and multidimensional relationship with Bangladesh is an essential component of India's long-term foreign policy goals.

Q7.Evaluation on Recent India–Pakistan Relations (2024-H)

Introduction:

India and Pakistan, both born out of the 1947 partition, have remained neighbors locked in persistent tension and conflict. Despite being geographically close, their relations are often described as that of "**distant neighbors**" due to mutual suspicion, unresolved territorial disputes, and cross-border hostilities. In recent years, ties have further deteriorated, leading to a state of **"cold peace"**, where formal diplomatic ties exist but meaningful cooperation remains absent.

Kashmir Dispute and the Revocation of Article 370:

The **Kashmir issue** continues to be the central point of conflict.

- While there were past efforts like the **Agra Summit (2001)** and **Lahore Bus Service**, these did not yield lasting peace.
- The **abrogation of Article 370 in 2019** by India was strongly protested by Pakistan.
- Since then, bilateral ties have become increasingly strained, with frequent rhetorical escalations and diplomatic downgrades.

Terrorism and Cross-Border Attacks:

Terrorism remains the most critical obstacle in bilateral relations.

Major incidents like the **2008 Mumbai attacks**, **2016 Uri attack**, and **2019 Pulwama attack** were attributed to **Pakistan-based groups**.

India has termed Pakistan a **state sponsor of terrorism**, while Pakistan denies such claims.

The lack of concrete action against groups like **Lashkar-e-Taiba** and **Jaish-e-Mohammed** has widened the trust deficit.

Border Clashes and Ceasefire Violations:

Tensions along the **Line of Control (LoC)** remain high.

- There have been **frequent ceasefire violations** and the use of new warfare tactics, including **drones** and **cross-border shelling**.
- The **Kargil conflict (1999)** remains a major memory of betrayal, as it occurred despite peace efforts.
- Current tensions point to a growing militarization of the border.

Breakdown in Diplomatic Engagement:
Diplomatic relations are at a historic low:
In response to the Pulwama attack, India **downgraded diplomatic ties** and suspended bilateral dialogues.

- Although **S. Jaishankar's visit to Pakistan for the 2024 SCO Summit** showed symbolic engagement, it has not led to any real thaw.
- Cultural exchanges and **cricket diplomacy** have also weakened; India has refused to play matches in Pakistan for the 2025 ICC Championship.

SAARC Impasse:
SAARC has become a **casualty of India–Pakistan tensions**.
The 2016 SAARC Summit, to be hosted by Pakistan, was **boycotted** by India and several other countries.

- The **regional organization has remained inactive**, weakening South Asian cooperation in trade, climate, and poverty eradication.

Strategic Competition and CPEC:
The **China–Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC)**, which runs through **Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK)**, is viewed by India as a **sovereignty violation**.

- CPEC symbolizes a growing **China-Pakistan strategic axis**, challenging India's position in the region.
- It also fuels concerns of **encirclement** under China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI).

Trade Relations and Economic Fallout:
Economic relations have sharply declined:

- India **granted MFN status to Pakistan in 1996**, but withdrew it in 2019 after Pulwama.
- **Trade in 2023–24** was minimal: India's exports to Pakistan were $1.2 billion; imports were only $3 million.
- This economic isolation has hurt **regional economic integration** and mutual growth potential.

Evaluation:
The trajectory of **India–Pakistan relations remains pessimistic** in the short term. The **absence of high-level talks**, **entrenched hostilities**, and **Pakistan's deepening ties with China** have added new layers of complexity.
However, mutual challenges like **climate change**, **terrorism**, **poverty**, and **public health** demand **regional cooperation**. Without dialogue and trust-building, South Asia's development will continue to suffer.

Conclusion:
India and Pakistan's strained relationship has far-reaching consequences—not just for the two countries but for the entire South Asian region. Despite historic bitterness, **peaceful coexistence** remains the only viable path forward. The future will depend on **political will**, **mutual restraint**, and

the ability to separate **people-to-people contact** from **political conflict**.

Q8.What was the main objective behind the formation of the India–Australia–USA–Japan alliance (QUAD)?

Introduction:

The *Quadrilateral Security Dialogue* (QUAD) is a strategic forum comprising India, Australia, the United States, and Japan. Initially conceptualized in 2007 but formalized in 2017, the alliance is aimed at promoting a **free, open, inclusive, and rules-based Indo-Pacific** region amid growing geopolitical tensions, especially due to China's assertiveness.

Protection of a rules-based international order:

QUAD is committed to upholding international law, freedom of navigation, and respect for sovereignty. The alliance seeks to defend the liberal world order and oppose coercion and unilateral actions in international waters.

Countering China's influence:

A key objective is to present a strategic counterweight to China's expanding economic and military presence, especially in the **South China Sea**, **East China Sea**, and **Indo-Pacific**. It addresses China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) and assertive foreign policy.

Maritime security and protection of free sea routes:

QUAD nations conduct **joint naval exercises** (like the Malabar Exercise) and enhance maritime surveillance to ensure freedom of navigation and secure trade routes across the Indo-Pacific.

Technological cooperation:

Member countries collaborate on **critical and emerging technologies** such as 5G, Artificial Intelligence, semiconductor supply chains, and cybersecurity. This aims to reduce dependency on authoritarian regimes and bolster tech resilience.

Humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR):

QUAD coordinates relief and support during natural disasters, pandemics, and emergencies. During **COVID-19**, the alliance pledged to supply **one billion vaccine doses** to the Indo-Pacific region, highlighting its humanitarian role.

Maintaining regional stability and strategic balance:

QUAD plays a balancing role in the Indo-Pacific power dynamics. It seeks to preserve peace, stability, and a multipolar regional order that ensures equitable development and collective security.

Evaluation:

In conclusion, QUAD has emerged as a **key strategic coalition** in 21st-century geopolitics, particularly for Indo-Pacific security. In 2024, the **fourth QUAD Summit** was held, with Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi actively participating, further solidifying India's role in this regional security framework. Though not a formal military alliance, QUAD's growing cooperation reflects its importance in shaping the future of Asia-Pacific geopolitics.

Q9.Significance of the Indo-Nepal Treaty of Peace and Friendship, 1950 (2024 H)

Introduction:

Though India and Nepal share civilizational ties rooted in history, their **modern diplomatic relationship** formally began in **1950**, with the signing of the **Treaty of Peace and Friendship**. This was a crucial moment for both nations—Nepal was seeking protection from possible Chinese expansionism, and India wanted to secure its northern borders.

Military and Strategic Foundation:

The treaty provided India a strategic edge in ensuring that Nepal would not align with any power hostile to India. In return, Nepal received support for preserving its sovereignty. Joint security understanding was especially vital in the context of **post-revolutionary China**.

Strengthening Economic and Social Ties:

The treaty allowed for **free movement of people and goods** across the Indo-Nepal border. Citizens of both countries could live, work, and own property in each other's territory, enabling deep socio-economic interdependence, particularly through **labour migration** and **cross-border trade**.

Maintaining Regional Stability:

The treaty encouraged both countries to cooperate in addressing **external threats**, preventing interference by third powers. It contributed to maintaining **political stability** in the Himalayas, a geopolitically sensitive area for South Asia.

Preservation of Nepal's Sovereignty:

Although India played a significant role in Nepal's development and defense, **Article 1** of the treaty assured **mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity**, thereby upholding Nepal's independence while fostering bilateral cooperation.

Political and Diplomatic Importance:

By signing this treaty, **India formally recognized Nepal as an independent state**. Diplomatic relations were strengthened through the opening of embassies, mutual visits, and alignment in several international forums.

Assessment:

The **1950 Indo-Nepal Treaty** laid the groundwork for an enduring partnership. However, in recent decades, several sections of Nepalese society and political leadership have **questioned the treaty**, alleging that it favors India disproportionately. Demands for **revision or replacement** have emerged, though India maintains that the treaty can be revised through mutual consent.

Conclusion:

The Indo-Nepal Treaty of Peace and Friendship remains a **cornerstone of bilateral relations**, though it must adapt to evolving political realities. A balanced renegotiation, if undertaken, could further strengthen mutual trust and cooperation.

Q.Discussion on Doklam in India-China Relations (2024 - H)

Doklam Dispute:

Introduction:

The Doklam standoff of 2017 marked a significant turning point in India-China relations. Located at the tri-junction of India, Bhutan, and China, Doklam has become a symbol of strategic rivalry and contested territorial claims, underscoring the fragility of peace along the Himalayan frontier.

The Conflict:

In June 2017, Chinese troops began constructing a

road in the Doklam plateau, a territory claimed by Bhutan but also disputed by China. India, invoking its special treaty relationship with Bhutan and perceiving a threat to its own security—particularly the vulnerable **Siliguri Corridor** (the "Chicken's Neck")—intervened to halt the construction. This resulted in a 73-day military standoff between the Indian Army and China's PLA (People's Liberation Army), making it one of the most serious border crises since the 1962 war.

Strategic Concerns:

China's road-building was not just a matter of infrastructure—it had deep geopolitical implications. Had the road been completed, it would have allowed the PLA easier access to India's northeastern region, thereby threatening the narrow Siliguri Corridor that connects the mainland to the Northeast. For India, defending Bhutan's claim was inseparable from defending its own strategic interests.

Diplomatic Resolution and Aftermath:

The standoff was eventually diffused in August 2017 through diplomatic negotiations. Both sides agreed to withdraw, although reports suggest that China has since resumed infrastructure development in the region. The episode revealed enduring mistrust, and the fragility of peace despite ongoing border agreements.

Legacy and Continuing Tensions:

The Doklam crisis set a precedent for subsequent clashes, notably the deadly **Galwan Valley clash of 2020**, reflecting deeper structural tensions in the India-China relationship. The incident has led to increased military preparedness, enhanced infrastructure development, and more cautious diplomatic engagement on both sides.

Conclusion:

The Doklam standoff illustrates the complex interplay of geography, security, and diplomacy in India-China relations. It underscores the urgent need for clearly demarcated borders, renewed confidence-building measures, and sustained dialogue to ensure long-term peace in the region.

Q. Write a short note on India's civil nuclear agreement with USA (2021-H)

Introduction:

When India conducted nuclear tests, the United States imposed sanctions due to non-compliance with global non-proliferation norms. However, India's peaceful and non-aggressive nuclear policy eventually opened the door to cooperation. In July 2005, during Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's U.S. visit, a joint statement with President George W. Bush laid the foundation of a civil nuclear agreement. After much negotiation, the deal was finalized and signed on **10 October 2008**. It is popularly known as the **123 Agreement**.

Main points of the agreement:

➤ The U.S. agreed to provide India with nuclear fuel and technology for civilian purposes.

➤ Out of India's 22 reactors, **14 were designated as civilian** and placed under the **IAEA safeguards**.

➤ These reactors are not for military use but for generating nuclear energy.

➤ The U.S. committed to uninterrupted supply of nuclear fuel unless India violates the agreement terms.

➤ India agreed to maintain the separation between civilian and military nuclear facilities and not use imported material for weapons.

Conclusion:

The Indo–U.S. Civil Nuclear Agreement was a **historic milestone** in India–U.S. relations. It ended India's nuclear isolation, enabled entry into global nuclear commerce, and marked India's recognition as a responsible nuclear power. Despite internal and external debates, it reflected India's growing diplomatic strength and strategic maturity.

Q.India–United States Relations in the Post–Cold War Era (2023-H)

Introduction:

India and the United States, the world's largest and oldest democracies respectively, have shared a complex relationship during the Cold War. However, after the Cold War ended, global geopolitics shifted significantly. India adopted a multi-aligned foreign policy and sought stronger ties with global powers, especially the United States. This marked a new chapter of strategic cooperation in multiple sectors.

India–U.S. Relations in the 21st Century: Key Aspects

1. Political Relations:

➤ High-level diplomatic visits began strengthening ties post-1994.

➤ In 2000, President Bill Clinton's visit to India was a milestone.

➤ In 2005, PM Manmohan Singh and President George W. Bush announced the framework for the Civil Nuclear Deal.

➤ PM Modi addressed the U.S. Congress in 2016 and held multiple summits with U.S. Presidents.

➤ In 2023, PM Modi's state visit and Biden's G20 visit to India further deepened ties.

2. Military Cooperation:

➤ Defense agreement signed in 2002.

➤ Key agreements:

- **LEMOA** (2016): Logistics support.
- **COMCASA** (2018): Secure communications.
- **BECA** (2020): Geospatial sharing.
- **SOSA** (2024): Systems interoperability.

➤ India is now a Major Defense Partner of the U.S.

➤ Cooperation under QUAD (since 2017) has enhanced Indo-Pacific security alignment.

3. Economic Relations:

➤ U.S. is one of India's largest trading partners.

➤ Bilateral trade exceeded $128 billion in 2023.

➤ Heavy U.S. investments by firms like Google, Amazon, and Microsoft.

➤ Indian IT companies play a vital role in U.S. digital economy and services.

4. Nuclear Cooperation:

➤ India faced U.S. sanctions after nuclear tests.

➤ In 2005, civil nuclear cooperation was announced.

➤ The **123 Agreement** (2008) allowed U.S.

nuclear fuel/tech transfer to India's civilian reactors.

➤ Marked India's entry into mainstream nuclear diplomacy despite being a non-NPT state.

5. Counterterrorism Cooperation:

➤ Joint Working Group on counterterrorism formed in 1997.

➤ Shared concerns after 9/11 and 26/11 attacks.

➤ Intelligence sharing and joint counterterrorism efforts have grown substantially.

6. Science & Technology Cooperation:

➤ Strong collaboration between **ISRO and NASA** in Earth observation and planetary exploration.

➤ Formation of **CSJWG (2005)** for civil space cooperation.

➤ **iCET (2022)** launched for advanced tech partnership in AI, quantum, 5G/6G, semiconductors.

➤ In 2024, India–U.S. signed a **Space Flight Agreement**, boosting mission-level interoperability.

Evaluation:

India–U.S. relations in the post–Cold War era have matured from mutual caution to comprehensive strategic partnership. Cooperation now spans defense, nuclear energy, counterterrorism, trade, and technology. The relationship is no longer transactional but based on shared democratic values and mutual interests. The re-election of Donald Trump in 2024 is expected to further shape the trajectory of Indo–U.S. ties in the coming years.

Q.Do you think the Sittwe Port located in the Rakhine region holds significance in India-Myanmar trade? *(2024-H)*

Introduction:

In the evolving geopolitical landscape of South and Southeast Asia, seaports have become vital instruments of trade, connectivity, and strategic assertion. The Sittwe Port in Myanmar's Rakhine region, developed with Indian assistance, stands as a key asset in India-Myanmar bilateral ties and India's broader regional strategy.

1. Strategic Gateway for India's Northeast:

Sittwe Port provides sea access to the landlocked Northeastern states, especially Mizoram, linking them with the Bay of Bengal. It forms a vital part of the Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and aligns with India's "Act East Policy."

2. Boost to Bilateral Trade and Economic Integration:

Through the Kaladan corridor, goods from Kolkata reach Sittwe by sea, then travel up the Kaladan River and by road to Mizoram. This route reduces transport time and cost, opening new commercial avenues between India and Myanmar, especially benefitting India's underdeveloped Northeast.

3. Strategic Counterbalance to China:

Amid growing Chinese presence in Myanmar through the Kyaukphyu Port and CMEC (China-Myanmar Economic Corridor), Sittwe serves as India's strategic foothold in the region. It enables India to maintain influence and ensure maritime access in the Bay of Bengal.

4. Infrastructure and Regional Development:

Developed with Indian funding and technical

support, the port has improved infrastructure in the Rakhine region, generating employment and aiding local development. It demonstrates India's commitment to inclusive regional growth.

5. Improved Regional Connectivity:

Sittwe enhances multimodal connectivity within BIMSTEC nations and complements India's larger Indo-Pacific vision. It strengthens people-to-people ties and facilitates cross-border cooperation.

6. Maritime Alternative to the Siliguri Corridor:

The port offers an alternative to the congested and vulnerable Siliguri Corridor, reducing India's logistical dependency on the narrow land strip and improving strategic mobility.

Conclusion:

Sittwe Port is more than a trade node—it is a linchpin in India's connectivity strategy, economic diplomacy, and regional balancing. It strengthens India-Myanmar ties, boosts Northeast India's integration, and reinforces India's presence in the Bay of Bengal and Southeast Asia.

Q.India's Civil Nuclear Agreement with the USA

Introduction:

After India conducted nuclear tests in 1998, the United States imposed sanctions. However, India's peaceful nuclear posture and growing global stature led to a shift in bilateral ties. A major turning point came with the joint statement on July 18, 2005, during Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's visit to Washington, which laid the foundation for the Civil Nuclear Agreement. The final agreement, also called the *123 Agreement*, was signed on **October 10, 2008**.

Key Features of the Agreement:

The USA agreed to supply nuclear materials and technologies for India's civilian nuclear reactors. Out of India's 22 nuclear reactors, 14 designated as *civilian* would be eligible for this cooperation. These 14 reactors would be placed under the safeguards of the *International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA).*

The agreement stipulated that the supplied nuclear fuel must be used only for civilian purposes. If India violated the terms, the U.S. could terminate fuel supply.

Conclusion:

The Indo-U.S. Civil Nuclear Agreement marked a historic shift in global nuclear diplomacy. It ended India's nuclear isolation, strengthened energy cooperation, and deepened Indo-U.S. strategic ties, highlighting India's responsible nuclear behavior and rising global influence.

Q. Analyse the recent tensions in India–China relations. (2021-H)

Introduction:

In the realm of contemporary global politics, India and China emerge as two of Asia's most consequential powers. Historically bound by civilizational ties and periods of cooperation, their bilateral relationship has increasingly become marked by geopolitical competition—particularly over unresolved border disputes. Although the post-Cold War era initially witnessed efforts toward normalization and growing engagement, recent years have seen a noticeable strain. The following

analysis highlights the evolving dimensions of these tensions.

i. Political Engagements and Shifts:

Despite periods of high-level diplomacy, the political trajectory of India-China relations has fluctuated. Landmark events such as Chinese Premier Li Peng's visit to India in 1991 and Indian Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao's return visit in 1993 laid the groundwork for a thaw. Notably, the 2005 and 2010 visits of Premier Wen Jiabao and the 2013 Border Cooperation Agreement marked attempts to stabilize ties. Between 2014 and 2019, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi Jinping met 18 times, suggesting intent for strategic dialogue. However, these gestures have been frequently undermined by China's assertive posture on border issues. Even the 2022 visit of Foreign Minister Wang Yi did little to reduce diplomatic mistrust.

ii. Cultural and Educational Exchanges:

India and China share a civilizational history that dates back to the spread of Buddhism and ancient trade routes. In the modern era, both nations sought to revive soft diplomacy. The 2006 Education Exchange Programme (EEP) institutionalized academic cooperation, and institutes like KHS in Agra now offer scholarships for Chinese students. Cultural exchanges through cinema—particularly Bollywood—have created avenues for people-to-people connection, even amidst strategic mistrust.

iii. Scientific and Technological Cooperation:

Despite rising friction, science and technology have provided occasional opportunities for collaboration. The 2014 MoU between ISRO and CNSA was a symbolic move toward peaceful cooperation in outer space. Subsequent agreements in 2015 and collaborative efforts in AI, big data, oceanography, and climate science in 2018 reflected mutual recognition of global technological challenges. However, such cooperation remains fragile in the face of broader strategic competition.

iv. Strategic and Defence Dynamics:

The strategic rivalry, deeply embedded in geopolitical anxieties, is shaped by proximity and military posturing. Though India and China have participated in joint military exercises such as *Hand-in-Hand* (since 2007) and shared forums like BRICS and the SCO, border militarization and trust deficits continue to undercut these efforts. China's increasing presence in the Indian Ocean, its alliance with Pakistan, and its infrastructural ambitions in the Himalayas through the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) remain concerns for India.

v. Economic Interdependence and Trade:

Paradoxically, even as tensions mount, economic interdependence has grown. China remains India's largest trading partner. Between 2015 and 2022, bilateral trade surged by over 90%, with trade volumes touching USD 136.2 billion in 2023. However, this asymmetry—in China's favour—has led to growing calls within India for greater economic diversification and self-reliance under initiatives like *Atmanirbhar Bharat.*

vi. The Border Dispute and Military Tensions:

The unresolved border remains the single most destabilizing factor. China's aggressive claims over Arunachal Pradesh, infrastructure build-up near the Line of Actual Control (LAC), and repeated transgressions—most notably the 2020 Galwan Valley clash—have eroded bilateral trust. These

incidents not only challenged the diplomatic status quo but also catalyzed a strategic recalibration in India's foreign and defence policies.

Conclusion:

The recent trajectory of India–China relations is defined by a paradox of high-level engagements coexisting with deep-rooted strategic mistrust. While cooperation in areas like trade, education, and science provides channels of engagement, unresolved disputes—particularly over the border—continue to dominate the bilateral narrative. As India's regional and global aspirations grow, the dynamics of its relationship with China will remain a critical determinant of Asian stability and global power realignments.

Q.Evaluation of India's Foreign Policy in the New Millennium

(Alternatively: India's Role in Foreign Policy as an Emerging Power)

Introduction:

In the new millennium, India has navigated an increasingly complex global order dominated by strategic rivalries among major powers like the United States, China, and Russia. Simultaneously, pressing challenges such as climate change, terrorism, and economic disparity have compelled India to adopt a more proactive, multifaceted foreign policy. Moving beyond the limitations of the Cold War-era non-alignment framework, India has reoriented its diplomatic approach to reflect the realities of a globalized, multipolar world.

i. Emergence of a Multi-Alignment Strategy:

India has transitioned from its earlier doctrine of non-alignment to a policy of multi-alignment. This approach enables India to cultivate strategic partnerships across ideological lines—with the United States, Russia, the European Union, and key Asian powers—while retaining autonomy in decision-making. The aim is to safeguard national interests without becoming entangled in great-power rivalries.

ii. Economic Diplomacy and Global Trade Integration:

India's foreign policy in the new millennium places strong emphasis on economic diplomacy. Active participation in organizations such as the WTO, BRICS, BIMSTEC, and G20 reflects India's desire to influence global trade rules. Moreover, efforts to negotiate Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), particularly with Southeast Asian and African nations, reflect a shift toward economic pragmatism.

iii. Neighbourhood First Policy:

Recognizing the strategic importance of regional stability, India has prioritized its relations with neighboring countries through the *Neighbourhood First* policy. Infrastructure projects like highway and rail links with Nepal, Bhutan, and Bangladesh; water-sharing agreements; and investments in regional connectivity signal India's commitment to South Asian cooperation. Platforms like SAARC and BIMSTEC serve as vehicles for this engagement.

iv. From Look East to Act East:

India's *Act East Policy*, launched in 2014 as a successor to the *Look East Policy*, has deepened India's engagement with ASEAN countries, Japan, and South Korea. The policy promotes trade, investment, maritime security, and cultural

diplomacy in the Indo-Pacific region, strategically counterbalancing China's influence.

v. Strategic Defense and Security Partnerships:

India has strengthened its defense and security apparatus through strategic partnerships. The signing of foundational agreements like LEMOA with the US, participation in the Quad (with Japan, the US, and Australia), and joint military exercises underscore India's strategic alignment with democratic powers in the Indo-Pacific region.

vi. Counter-Terrorism Diplomacy:

India has emerged as a global voice against terrorism. It has consistently raised concerns about Pakistan-sponsored cross-border terrorism at international platforms such as the UN. Collaborations with countries like the US, France, and Israel have enhanced intelligence sharing, cyber security, and counter-terror operations.

vii. Aspirations for Global Leadership and Institutional Reform:

India has advocated strongly for reforming multilateral institutions. It seeks a permanent seat on the United Nations Security Council (UNSC), reflecting its growing global stature. India's contributions to peacekeeping missions, climate initiatives, and sustainable development goals reinforce its claim as a responsible global actor.

viii. Soft Power Projection:

India's rich cultural heritage, bolstered by yoga, Ayurveda, literature, and cinema, has become a cornerstone of its soft power. The celebration of International Yoga Day and promotion of Indian languages and traditions abroad have amplified India's cultural influence on the global stage.

ix. Response to China and the Indo-Pacific Strategy:

India's foreign policy has taken a strategic turn in response to China's aggressive expansionism and the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). India has invested in alternative regional connectivity projects such as the Chabahar Port in Iran and developed closer naval and diplomatic ties in the Indo-Pacific to ensure freedom of navigation and maritime security.

Conclusion:

India's foreign policy in the new millennium reflects a decisive shift from moral posturing to strategic engagement. With a balance of realism and idealism, India has positioned itself as an emerging power in the global order. However, challenges remain: managing the China-Pakistan axis, securing energy routes, and balancing internal developmental needs with international ambitions. The future of India's foreign policy lies in adapting to a rapidly evolving global scenario while upholding national interest through a prudent mix of diplomacy, defense, and development.

Q.Identify the key pillars of India's maritime security in the post-Cold War era. *(2022-H)*

Introduction:

The end of the Cold War in 1991 reshaped the global strategic landscape. For India, maritime security gained increased importance due to the emergence of new threats and regional power rivalries. With its vast coastline and critical dependence on maritime trade, India's maritime domain became central to its security, economy, and foreign policy.

Q.Key Pillars of India's Maritime Security in the Post-Cold War Era:

1. Strategic Response to China's Maritime Expansion:

China's "String of Pearls" strategy—developing ports and bases across the Indian Ocean—threatens India's regional influence. The leasing of Sri Lanka's Hambantota port to China and the activities under the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) reflect growing Chinese assertiveness. India perceives the increasing presence of Chinese submarines and warships in the Indian Ocean as a direct strategic challenge.

2. Protection of Sea Lanes of Communication (SLOCs):

Around 90% of India's trade by volume moves through sea routes. Strategic chokepoints like the Strait of Hormuz and Strait of Malacca are vital for energy imports and trade flow but remain vulnerable to threats like piracy, terrorism, and geopolitical tensions. Securing these SLOCs is essential for economic stability.

3. Combatting Piracy and Maritime Crimes:

The Indian Ocean, particularly near the Somali coast, has witnessed a rise in piracy. Indian merchant vessels and crew are often targets. These non-traditional threats require coordinated regional and international responses, including patrolling, joint naval exercises, and maritime cooperation.

4. Coastal and Port Security:

The 26/11 Mumbai attacks exposed glaring gaps in India's coastal security architecture. Post-2008, India has taken steps to improve surveillance, maritime domain awareness, and port security, including strengthening the role of the Indian Navy and Coast Guard. However, gaps still exist in certain vulnerable stretches of the coastline.

5. Safeguarding the Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ):

Illegal fishing and exploitation of marine resources by foreign vessels in India's EEZ undermine national interests. India must protect its marine biodiversity and strategic resources by enforcing maritime law and enhancing its monitoring capabilities.

6. Multilateral Naval and Strategic Cooperation:

To counterbalance China and ensure regional maritime stability, India has deepened its engagement with forums like the Quad (with the U.S., Japan, and Australia). This has enabled joint naval exercises like *Malabar* and enhanced interoperability and strategic coordination. India is also cooperating with nations like France, the U.K., and ASEAN states to build a regional security network.

Conclusion:

India's maritime security in the post-Cold War era is shaped by both traditional threats (like rival navies) and non-traditional challenges (like piracy and illegal fishing). As India's economic and strategic interests become increasingly ocean-centric, it must develop a blue-water navy, modernize coastal infrastructure, and strengthen diplomatic engagement to safeguard its maritime domain.

Q.India's 'Look East Policy' has now transformed into the 'Act East Policy' – Explain. (2021-H)

Introduction:

India's *Look East Policy* was launched in 1991, in the wake of economic liberalization, with the aim of strengthening economic and strategic relations with Southeast and East Asian countries. It primarily focused on trade and diplomatic engagement. However, in 2014, this policy was reoriented and rebranded by the Narendra Modi government as the *Act East Policy*. This new framework signified a shift from passive engagement to proactive and strategic participation across multiple sectors including defense, connectivity, and cultural diplomacy.

/Features of the Look East Policy:

The *Look East Policy* laid the foundational groundwork for India's engagement with Asia-Pacific nations. Key characteristics include:

Economic Orientation: The policy was primarily driven by economic diplomacy, aiming to integrate India with the dynamic economies of Southeast Asia. It encouraged bilateral trade, foreign investment, and regional connectivity.

ASEAN-Centric Approach: ASEAN remained at the core of the policy. India's dialogue partnership with ASEAN in 1992 eventually evolved into a strategic partnership, reinforcing its regional presence.

//Transformation into Act East Policy (2014):

The *Act East Policy*, announced during the East Asia Summit in Nay Pyi Taw, Myanmar in 2014, marked a strategic upgrade of its predecessor. Unlike the *Look East Policy*, which was often criticized as being symbolic, the *Act East Policy* emphasized implementation, integration, and initiative. Key features include: **Strategic and Defense Cooperation:** Under *Act East*, India began actively pursuing defense collaborations, joint military exercises, and security dialogues with countries like Japan, Vietnam, Indonesia, and Australia.

Indo-Pacific Vision: The policy aligns with India's larger geopolitical strategy in the Indo-Pacific, promoting maritime security and freedom of navigation in partnership with other democratic powers.

Development of Northeast India: A vital focus of the *Act East Policy* is to transform Northeast India into a land bridge to Southeast Asia. Infrastructure projects such as highways, rail connectivity, and border trade points have been prioritized.

Cultural and Soft Power Diplomacy: India is leveraging civilizational links, particularly Buddhism and Indian diaspora networks, to strengthen people-to-people ties. Cultural exchanges, educational initiatives, and tourism are actively promoted.

Conclusion:

The shift from *Look East* to *Act East* reflects India's evolving foreign policy in response to changing regional dynamics and global power shifts. It marks a strategic repositioning of India as an assertive stakeholder in Asia, committed to fostering regional integration, securing maritime interests, and countering emerging security threats. In essence, the *Act East Policy* embodies India's aspiration to play a more influential role in shaping the Indo-Pacific order while deepening its

economic and cultural footprint in East and Southeast Asia.

Q. **What were the major external challenges faced by India during the Cold War?** *(2021-H)*

Introduction:

Following the end of the Second World War, the global political landscape became polarized between two major blocs — the capitalist bloc led by the United States and the socialist bloc led by the Soviet Union. The rivalry between these superpowers ushered in the Cold War era (1945–1991). As a newly independent nation, India adopted a policy of *non-alignment*, refusing to join either bloc. Nevertheless, this neutral stance did not shield India from several external challenges that shaped its foreign and security policies.

1.Superpower Pressure:

India's commitment to non-alignment was tested by both the US and the USSR, who sought to expand their spheres of influence. The United States, in particular, viewed India with suspicion due to its closer ties with the USSR and often extended greater strategic support to Pakistan. This created geopolitical complications and limited India's maneuvering space in international affairs.

2. Breakdown of India-China Relations:

Initially marked by cordiality ("Hindi-Chini Bhai Bhai"), India's relationship with China deteriorated over the Tibet issue and unresolved border disputes. The situation escalated into the 1962 Sino-Indian war, resulting in a severe military setback for India. This exposed India's defence vulnerabilities and led to a temporary reliance on American military assistance, while also accelerating India's strategic alignment with the Soviet Union.

3. Conflicts with Pakistan:

India engaged in two major wars with Pakistan during the Cold War — in 1965 and in 1971. The latter resulted in the creation of Bangladesh and was a strategic victory for India. However, both wars strained India militarily, economically, and diplomatically, and underscored the persistent threat posed by its western neighbour, often backed by the US and China.

4. Nuclear Policy and International Isolation:

India's first nuclear test in 1974 (Operation *Smiling Buddha*) triggered international backlash. Western countries, particularly the US, imposed sanctions and cut off access to nuclear technology. These restrictions hindered India's nuclear energy program and subjected it to growing international scrutiny and pressure.

5. Economic Dependency and Aid Politics:

India's economy in the early post-independence period was heavily reliant on foreign aid. The Cold War context made such aid contingent on ideological alignment, especially from Western countries. This placed India in a diplomatically delicate position and occasionally challenged the principles of non-alignment.

6. Refugee Crisis during the Bangladesh War:

The 1971 Bangladesh Liberation War resulted in the migration of nearly 10 million refugees into India. This sudden influx placed immense pressure on India's economy and infrastructure, creating one of the biggest humanitarian and logistical challenges of the Cold War period.

7. Rejection of the NPT and Global Opposition:
India opposed the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) of 1968, arguing that it legitimized the monopoly of existing nuclear powers while denying the same right to others. Refusing to sign the treaty led to India being viewed as an outlier in global nuclear politics and subjected it to diplomatic isolation and technological denial regimes.

Evaluation:
In conclusion, despite adopting a non-aligned foreign policy, India had to navigate numerous external challenges during the Cold War — from military conflicts and diplomatic isolation to economic pressures and refugee burdens. Yet, through strategic autonomy, cautious alliances, and persistent diplomacy, India preserved its sovereignty and laid the groundwork for its emergence as a significant player in the post-Cold War world.

1. Do you think India's role in the Russia-Ukraine war was important? (2023-H)

Introduction:
The Russia-Ukraine war, which erupted in February 2022, is one of the most defining geopolitical crises of the 21st century. It has disrupted global security frameworks and triggered serious economic, diplomatic, and humanitarian consequences. While major global powers aligned themselves with opposing sides, India adopted a strategically cautious and balanced approach. Rather than taking sides, India consistently advocated peace, upheld its national interest, and played a constructive role through humanitarian aid and diplomacy. In this context, India's role in the conflict assumes considerable importance.

1.India's Neutral Stance and Strategic Balancing:
From the very beginning, India maintained neutrality. It refrained from openly supporting or condemning either side. India abstained from voting on several UN resolutions critical of Russia. This diplomatic choice allowed it to retain strong relations with both the West and Russia, demonstrating India's strategic autonomy in foreign policy.

2.Humanitarian Initiatives and Evacuation Efforts:
India's launch of "Operation Ganga" ensured the safe evacuation of around 20,000 Indian citizens from Ukraine. This timely and efficient mission received international appreciation. In addition, India sent medical and humanitarian aid to Ukraine. Prime Minister Narendra Modi also held dialogues with both President Putin and President Zelenskyy, reiterating the need for immediate cessation of hostilities and dialogue—thus enhancing India's image as a peace-seeking power.

3.Safeguarding Global Food and Energy Security:
The war disrupted global supply chains, especially for oil, gas, and grains. India secured discounted oil imports from Russia, which helped stabilize domestic prices. Though this drew criticism from some Western quarters, India firmly defended its sovereign right to prioritize its energy needs. Simultaneously, it exported grains to food-insecure nations, reflecting its role as a stabilizing force in the Global South.

4.Engagement in Multiple Geopolitical Forums:
India remained diplomatically active in both

Western and non-Western alliances. It participated in QUAD (with the US, Japan, and Australia) while also engaging with Russia and China through BRICS and the SCO. This dual engagement enhanced India's strategic positioning and reinforced its aspiration to play a multipolar leadership role.

5.Moral Diplomacy and Global Standing:

India consistently emphasized peaceful negotiations over military aggression. Its stand has been viewed globally as morally grounded, in contrast to the aggressive postures of other powers. India's appeal for dialogue and its measured rhetoric elevated its international credibility as a responsible democratic power.

Conclusion:

India's role in the Russia-Ukraine war, though limited in military terms, was diplomatically and morally significant. It upheld neutrality without isolation, extended humanitarian support without geopolitical overreach, and protected national interest without compromising global responsibility. In doing so, India reasserted its place as an emerging global actor capable of influencing peace-oriented outcomes in an increasingly polarized world.

2. Write a short note on: Why has India not signed the NPT and CTBT?

Introduction:

India has refused to sign both the *Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT)* of 1970 and the *Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty (CTBT)* of 1996. India's refusal stems from principled objections based on fairness, strategic autonomy, and concerns over global nuclear inequities.

1. Discriminatory Structure of the Treaties:

India views both treaties as inherently unequal. The NPT legitimizes the possession of nuclear weapons by five countries (the U.S., U.K., France, China, and Russia), while permanently denying this right to others. The CTBT similarly allows existing nuclear powers to retain their arsenals, despite banning further tests.

2. Unequal Commitments:

While non-nuclear states are prohibited from developing weapons under these treaties, nuclear-armed states face no binding timeline or enforcement mechanism for disarmament. India objects to this imbalance of obligations.

3. Ineffectiveness in Preventing Proliferation:

India argues that these treaties have failed in their basic purpose. Since the NPT's inception, more states have acquired nuclear weapons, and clandestine programs have flourished. The CTBT, though never fully in force, also failed to prevent nuclear testing by several states.

4. Strategic Concerns and National Security:

India believes that joining the NPT/CTBT without reciprocal disarmament by nuclear powers would compromise its own security. The treaties were introduced only after major powers had developed strong arsenals, further reinforcing power asymmetries in the global order.

5. India's Alternative Vision:

India advocates for universal, non-discriminatory, and verifiable disarmament. It upholds a credible minimum deterrence policy and a voluntary

moratorium on nuclear testing, without formally signing the CTBT.

Conclusion:

India's refusal to sign the NPT and CTBT reflects its desire to maintain strategic autonomy, oppose discriminatory regimes, and promote an equitable framework for disarmament. While it remains outside these treaties, India continues to act as a responsible nuclear power committed to global peace and restraint.

Φ 2024 (H) – Short Notes in India's Foreign Policy (English Version)

1. Who wrote *The Making of India's Foreign Policy* and when?

Jayantanuja Bandyopadhyay in 1970.

2. Why is India an important member of the SCO?

India's membership strengthens regional cooperation on security, trade, and counter-terrorism in Central Asia.

3. What are the five principles of Panchsheel?

(i) Mutual respect for territorial integrity and sovereignty

(ii) Mutual non-aggression

(iii) Mutual non-interference in internal affairs

(iv) Equality and mutual benefit

(v) Peaceful coexistence

4. What was Operation Cactus (1988)?

India intervened militarily in the Maldives to stop a coup and restore its government.

5. What are two key policies under the Gujral Doctrine?

(i) Non-interference in neighbors' internal matters

(ii) Enhanced economic cooperation with neighboring countries

6. When and why was the India–China Joint Working Group established?

In 1988, to improve bilateral ties and peacefully resolve border issues.

7. Why has India not signed the CTBT?

(i) To maintain its nuclear deterrent capability

(ii) To avoid international control over its nuclear policy

8. Why did India sign the US–India '123 Agreement'?

In 2005, to access American civil nuclear technology and fuel, strengthening energy security.

9. What are the main objectives of BRICS?

(i) Promote development and economic cooperation among emerging economies

(ii) Advocate for a fairer global governance structure representing the Global South

10. What are two markers of 'Emerging India'?

(i) Post-1991 liberalization and rapid economic

growth
(ii) Leadership in IT and digital innovation

11. Why was the IPKF deployed to Sri Lanka?
In 1987, under the Indo-Sri Lanka Accord, to disarm Tamil militants and restore peace.

12. When and why did India and South Africa celebrate 30 years of diplomatic ties?
In 2023, to mark ties established in 1993 after apartheid, strengthening cooperation.

13. When and why did India withdraw Pakistan's MFN status?
In February 2019, after the Pulwama attack, reflecting a national security stance.

14. What were India's key messages at the G-20 Summit 2023?
(i) Inclusive, sustainable development
(ii) Digital public infrastructure
(iii) Global health security post-COVID-19

15. What is the Sagarmala Project and when was it launched?
Launched in 2015, it aims to modernize ports, improve coastal infrastructure, and boost employment.

16. What are the core ideologies of India's foreign policy?
(i) Non-alignment
(ii) Panchsheel principles
(iii) Regional cooperation with neighbors

17. Did India support the idea of an 'All Weather Friendship'?
No, it refers to China–Pakistan ties; India maintains strategic autonomy and avoids unconditional alignments.

18. What were two main differences between India and China in the 1962 war?
(i) Disputes over Aksai Chin and Arunachal Pradesh
(ii) Lack of a mutually agreed border

19. When and between whom was the Simla Agreement signed?
In July 1972, between Indira Gandhi and Zulfikar Ali Bhutto to normalize Indo-Pak relations post-1971 war.

20. What were two foreign-policy ideologies under PM Vajpayee?
(i) Asserting India as a nuclear power for strategic balance
(ii) Promoting peaceful coexistence and neighborly dialogue

21. Why did India become a nuclear power?
(i) To assert strategic autonomy and global balance
(ii) To meet domestic energy demands

22. What were two causes of the 1999 Kargil War?
(i) Pakistan's infiltration into Indian territory
(ii) An attempt to alter the Kashmir status quo

23. Why is the Tibetan Plateau a point of tension between India and China?
Its high-altitude gives China a strategic advantage; infrastructure buildup threatens India's Himalayan security.

24. What are the key reasons behind the India–Bhutan Friendship Treaty?
Shared cultural, geographic, and historical ties; it supports mutual strategic cooperation. First signed in 1949, revised in 2007.

25. When did India and the EU become strategic partners?

In 2004, expanding cooperation beyond trade to include security, climate, and innovation.

26. What are two foreign-policy failures for India?
(i) SAARC's failure in achieving regional integration
(ii) Unresolved border disputes with China

27. Is the concept of "Extended Neighborhood" a milestone in Indian foreign policy?
Yes, it reflects India's expanded engagement with Africa, the Middle East, and East Asia in trade and security.

28. What is a CBM (Confidence-Building Measure)? Give one example.
CBMs reduce tensions between rival states. Example: India–Pakistan hotline and non-attack agreement on nuclear facilities.

29. What are the main contentious issues between India and Bangladesh?
(i) Water-sharing disputes (e.g., Teesta)
(ii) Border problems: smuggling, illegal entry
(iii) Illegal immigration into Indian states

30. Why is Myanmar important for India?
For Act East connectivity, Northeast security, and access to natural resources like gas and oil.

31. Why did India join the SCO?
To strengthen regional security, counter terrorism, and increase trade ties with Central and Inner Asian countries.

Ψ A Brief Note on International Terrorism (2021-P)

Introduction:
In the modern era, international terrorism has emerged as a pressing global concern. It threatens not only individual nations but also the collective security, stability, and progress of humanity. Terrorism involves deliberate acts of violence carried out to advance political, religious, or ideological objectives. With time, it has transcended borders and become a global menace.

Definition and Features of International Terrorism:
International terrorism refers to terrorist activities that involve more than one country—either in planning, execution, or impact—and aim to influence global or regional politics.

The key features of international terrorism include:

Cross-border impact: Even if the origin is domestic, consequences often spread internationally.

Political or ideological objectives: Goals include toppling governments or enforcing specific ideologies or religious laws.

Civilian targeting: Attacks often deliberately target civilians to provoke fear and chaos.

Technological use: Terrorist groups use digital platforms like social media for recruitment, planning, and propaganda.

Illicit funding networks: They depend on global funding sources, arms smuggling, drug trade, and human trafficking.

Causes of International Terrorism:

Religious fundamentalism: Misinterpretation of religious texts fosters radicalization.

Political repression: Oppressed or marginalized communities may become vulnerable to extremist influence.

International double standards: Hypocrisy or bias in foreign policy by powerful nations fosters resentment.

Socio-economic deprivation: Poverty, lack of education, and joblessness can drive individuals toward terrorism.

Arms proliferation: Easy availability of weapons on the black market enables terrorist operations.

Major International Terrorist Organizations:
Notable global terrorist groups include:

- **Al-Qaeda**
- **ISIS (Islamic State)**
- **Boko Haram**
- **Taliban**
- **Lashkar-e-Taiba**
- **Jaish-e-Mohammed**

Impacts of International Terrorism:

Mass casualties: Large-scale loss of innocent lives and long-term trauma.

Economic disruption: Terror attacks damage tourism, foreign investment, infrastructure, and education.

Political instability: Governments may collapse; authoritarianism and military interventions increase.

Rise in xenophobia: Particularly Islamophobia, leading to societal division and unrest.

Global insecurity: Mistrust among nations intensifies, increasing defense budgets and arms competition.

Conclusion:
International terrorism is a deeply rooted global challenge that cannot be defeated by military means alone. It requires collective international efforts—combining intelligence sharing, socio-economic development, justice, and inclusive governance. Humanity must transcend narrow divisions of nation, religion, and race to create a peaceful, secure, and united world.

Ψ What was the role of India in the Non-Aligned Movement? (2022-P)

Introduction:
In the post-Second World War period, the world was divided into two ideological and military blocs: the capitalist bloc led by the United States and the socialist bloc led by the Soviet Union. Amid this Cold War rivalry, many newly independent countries from Asia, Africa, and Latin America sought to avoid being drawn into either camp. This gave rise to the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM). India emerged as one of the most prominent leaders and active participants in shaping this movement.

India as a Founding Member of NAM:
India was a key architect of the NAM. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, India helped convene the first NAM summit in Belgrade in 1961, alongside Yugoslavia's Tito, Egypt’s Nasser, Ghana’s Nkrumah, and Indonesia’s Sukarno. This group of five leaders formed the

foundation of the NAM, advocating for a policy of non-alignment in international affairs.

Advocacy for Peace and Disarmament:
India consistently advocated for peaceful coexistence and disarmament. Nehru proposed the concept of the Panchsheel principles (mutual respect, non-aggression, non-interference, equality, and peaceful coexistence) as the basis of international relations. In 1954, India called for a ban on nuclear testing at the United Nations, aligning with NAM's goal of promoting global peace and security.

Stand Against Colonialism and Racial Discrimination:
India, having experienced colonial exploitation itself, played a vocal role in supporting anti-colonial and anti-racist movements. It condemned the apartheid policy of South Africa and supported decolonization efforts in Africa, Asia, and Latin America from the NAM platform.

Voice of the Global South (Third World):
India emerged as a leading advocate for the interests of developing nations. It raised issues such as economic disparity, technological dependence, trade inequalities, and the need for fair development aid. At various NAM and UN forums, India demanded a New International Economic Order (NIEO) to bridge the gap between the Global North and South.

Diplomatic Initiatives at Global Platforms:
India actively used its NAM position to voice concerns on global crises. It supported Palestinian self-determination, criticized American aggression in Vietnam, and opposed authoritarian regimes in Latin America. India's diplomacy projected NAM as a moral force in world politics.

Evaluation:
India's role in the Non-Aligned Movement was foundational, visionary, and morally influential. Through Nehru's leadership and subsequent diplomatic efforts, India helped define NAM's principles and objectives. While India later faced criticism for occasionally leaning towards the Soviet bloc during the Cold War, it never formally joined any military alliance. Even today, India continues to uphold the values of strategic autonomy and multilateral cooperation rooted in the NAM legacy.

ψ *"India-ASEAN Relations (2022-P)"*

Introduction:
In the evolving landscape of global geopolitics, India's relations with ASEAN (Association of Southeast Asian Nations) have grown into one of the most strategic and multifaceted partnerships. Initiated in the early 1990s, this engagement has developed from modest sectoral dialogues to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP) by 2022. ASEAN, formed in 1967, comprises 10 member states and aims to promote economic, political, security, and socio-cultural cooperation in the Southeast Asian region.

Historical Background of India-ASEAN Relations:
India became a Sectoral Dialogue Partner of ASEAN in 1992 and was upgraded to a full Dialogue Partner in 1996. This laid the groundwork for regular engagement. In 2002, annual summits

were instituted, further deepening ties. By 2012, the partnership was elevated to a Strategic Partnership. In 2022, marking 30 years of formal relations, India and ASEAN announced their transition to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP), signifying a more institutionalized and diversified cooperation.

India's Policy Framework:
India's engagement with ASEAN began with the "Look East Policy" in 1991, emphasizing economic diplomacy with East and Southeast Asia. In 2014, Prime Minister Narendra Modi rebranded this approach as the "Act East Policy," underlining not just economic, but also political, strategic, and defense cooperation with ASEAN and the wider Indo-Pacific region.

Economic Relations:
Economic collaboration remains central to India-ASEAN ties. The ASEAN-India Free Trade Agreement (AIFTA), implemented in 2010, catalyzed trade growth. As of FY 2023–24, bilateral trade reached approximately $122 billion, making ASEAN one of India's top trading partners. Additionally, ASEAN countries have contributed significantly to FDI inflows into India between 2000 and 2023, enhancing sectors like infrastructure, telecom, and manufacturing.

Political and Strategic Relations:
India and ASEAN share a commitment to preserving peace, stability, and freedom of navigation in the Indo-Pacific. Their strategic cooperation spans maritime security, counterterrorism, cyber security, disaster relief, and defense. India actively engages in bilateral and multilateral defense exercises with ASEAN countries such as MILAN, SIMBEX (with Singapore), and Samudra Shakti (with Indonesia). The India-ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting further institutionalizes this collaboration.

Cultural and People-to-People Ties:
India and Southeast Asia share deep-rooted civilizational links. Hinduism, Buddhism, Sanskrit, and Ramayana traditions have significantly influenced the cultural fabric of ASEAN countries. India and ASEAN foster these historical ties through programs such as the ASEAN-India Youth Summit, cultural festivals, and scholarship exchanges. The year 2025 has been declared as the "ASEAN-India Tourism Year" to boost cultural connectivity and tourism exchange.

Conclusion/Evaluation:
India-ASEAN relations have evolved into a robust and mutually beneficial partnership that integrates political trust, economic interdependence, strategic alignment, and cultural affinity. Despite some hurdles such as non-tariff barriers and geopolitical pressures from China, the foundation remains strong. For India, ASEAN is a cornerstone in fulfilling the objectives of the Act East Policy, while for ASEAN, India offers a vital strategic counterbalance and economic partner. With sustained engagement, this partnership is poised to deepen further in the coming decades.